

Observation Scheduler with Claude: Walkthrough

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What this does

Claude reads your teacher list and master schedule, checks your Google Calendar for conflicts, and proposes 20-minute walkthroughs that never land on top of a meeting. You approve the list, then Claude puts the events on your calendar. Setup takes about 30 minutes, and you write no code.

At Earlham, this replaced the walkthrough spreadsheet and the principal and secretary hours spent keeping it current.

Before you start

Accounts

- **A paid Claude plan** (Pro, Max, Team or Enterprise). Cowork and its projects need one.
- **The Claude desktop app** for Mac or Windows. Cowork, the mode that can read and write files on your computer, runs there.
- **A Google Workspace account** that owns, or can edit, the calendar where the observations should go.

Files (save both in one folder)

File	What's in it	Tips
Teacher list	Name, staff ID, email	Export from your SIS as CSV or Excel. Homeroom or core teachers only, to start
Master schedule	When each teacher is actually teaching, and what	Include real clock times, not just period numbers. If your schedule says "Period 3," add the bell schedule too

A PDF works, but a spreadsheet is more reliable. Also list days with no school, early outs, and anything else Claude can't see on your calendar (testing weeks, field trips).

Leave out: anything about students. Teacher names, emails and class times are all this needs.

Set it up

1. **Make the folder.** Create a folder such as `Classroom Observations` and put the teacher list and master schedule in it.
2. **Connect Google Calendar and Gmail.** In the Claude desktop app, select **Customize** in the sidebar, then **Connectors**. Find **Google Calendar**, select **Connect**, and sign in with the work account that holds your calendar. Do the same for **Gmail**.
 - Gmail is optional. It lets Claude email teachers a heads-up later.
 - On a Team or Enterprise plan, an organization Owner has to turn these connectors on first.
 - If Google says *"Access blocked: your institution's admin needs to review Claude,"* your Google Workspace admin must mark Claude as trusted under **Security > Access and data control > API controls**.
3. **Create the project.** Open **Cowork**. Under **Projects** in the left sidebar, select **+**, then **Use an existing folder**, and pick your `Classroom Observations` folder. Claude can now read the files in it and save new ones there.
4. **Add instructions.** In the project's **Instructions** box, paste something like:

This project schedules 20-minute classroom walkthroughs for me. My calendar is on the connected Google account. Never create, change or delete calendar events until I approve the list. Keep a running log of every scheduled observation in `observations_log.csv` in this folder.

5. **Check the connectors are on.** In a new task, select **+** in the message box, then **Connectors**, and make sure Google Calendar is switched on.
6. **Keep Claude asking first.** Leave the permission mode in the message box on **Manual**, which asks before acting, so Claude checks with you before it writes to your calendar.

The first prompt

Start a new task inside the project and paste this, changing the dates:

I want to schedule teacher observations. Use the teacher list and master schedule in this folder, and check my Google Calendar for conflicts. Schedule two 20-minute observations per day from October 20 through November 13, only during times a teacher is teaching. No school on [dates]. Don't book anything over an existing calendar event, and don't schedule the same teacher twice. Show me the full list as a table for review first. Don't create any calendar events until I approve.

What comes back is a table with date, time, teacher, room and subject. Claude may first ask a question or two, such as which column holds the class times or whether planning periods count. Answer them; that's normal.

Check the table before you approve anything:

- ☐ Every teacher appears once
- ☐ No slot lands during lunch, recess or a teacher's planning period
- ☐ No slot overlaps a meeting on your calendar
- ☐ No-school days and early outs are skipped

Approve, then book

1. **Fix what's wrong in plain English.** For example: "Move Smith off Friday, she has a field trip" or "Nothing before 8:30." Ask for the updated table.
2. **Approve.** Say: "Approved. Create these as events on my calendar, with no guests yet." Claude asks permission before each calendar change; allow them.
3. **Spot-check your calendar.** Open Google Calendar and confirm the events landed on the right days and times.
4. **Invite teachers only when you're ready.** Say: "Add each teacher as a guest on their observation and send the invite." Try it on one event first, ideally one with yourself as the guest. Invites email teachers, and they can't be unsent.
5. **Log it.** Ask Claude to update `observations_log.csv`. Next round, it starts from that log, so no one gets doubled up.

Make it yours

Add rules one at a time and re-check the table after each. Rules that worked at Earlham, or that principals ask for:

Rule	Say something like
Start at the top of the lesson	"Start each observation when the class period starts, not partway through."
Group by subject	"Put all math teachers in the first week and PE in the second."
Rotate subjects	"If I saw a teacher in reading last round, observe math this time."
Catch the ones you missed	"Check the log. Schedule anyone I haven't seen yet first."
Protect certain days	"Nothing on Mondays" or "Skip third grade on the 14th, they're testing."
Spread it out	"No more than one teacher per grade on the same day."

Make it repeatable. Once a round works, ask Claude: "Write down the rules we used in `rules.md` in this folder." Next round, start with: "Schedule the next round using `rules.md` and the log."

If something goes wrong

What you see	Try this
Claude can't see your calendar	Check that Google Calendar is switched on under + > Connectors in that task, and that you signed in with the right Google account
"Access blocked" when signing in to Google	Your Google Workspace admin has to trust Claude (see Set it up, step 2)
Observations land during lunch or planning	Your schedule is missing clock times. Add the bell schedule, or tell Claude which periods to skip
Two teachers in the same slot	Say: "I can only be in one room at a time. No overlapping observations."

What you see	Try this
Events land at the wrong hour	Tell Claude your time zone
Someone got scheduled twice	Ask Claude to check <code>observations_log.csv</code> before building the next list

Guardrails

Keep student data out of this project. Teacher names, emails and class times are fine; anything FERPA-protected is not.

- **Review before booking.** The list is a draft until you approve it.
- **No guests until you're sure.** Events with no guests are private to your calendar. Invites email teachers and can't be unsent.
- **On a personal Claude plan,** turn off **Settings > Privacy > Help improve Claude** so your chats aren't used for model training.
- **Use your district's account rules.** If your district has a Claude Team or Enterprise plan, use it instead of a personal one.

Sources

- [Organize your tasks with projects in Claude Cowork](#)
- [Get started with Claude Cowork](#)
- [Get started with connectors](#)
- [Use Google Workspace connectors](#)